system and NIC might ‘trust’ each other – a trust he could exploit to get into NIC. And NIC did everything.

NIC assigned domain names – the ‘.com’ or ‘.net’ at the end of an email address – for the entire Internet. NIC also controlled the US military’s own internal defence data network, known as MILNET.

NIC also published the communication protocol standards for the Internet. Called RFCs (Request for Comments), these technical specifications allowed one computer on the Internet to talk to another . . . Perhaps most importantly, NIC controlled the reverse look-up service on the Internet. Whenever someone connects to another site across the Internet, he or she typically types in the site name – say, ariel.unimelb.edu.au at the University of Melbourne. The computer then translates the alphabetical name into a numerical address – the IP address. All the computers on the Internet need this IP address to relay the packets of data onto the final destination computer. NIC decided how Internet computers would translate the alphabetical name into an IP address, and vice versa.

If you controlled NIC, you had phenomenal power on the Internet. You could, for example, simply make Australia disappear. Or you could turn it into Brazil.

We got inside, and the feeling was overwhelming. Some people make the mistake of saying it’s like playing God: it’s not, because God, if he’s God, already has all the answers. We were twenty. The joy was an explorer’s joy at breaking through to a new frontier despite all the odds. I created a back door into the system for future adventures. This system was awesome, and I felt almost subdued at the connectivity on offer: for me, and this is relevant to my future work on WikiLeaks, I saw a perfect join between a mathematical truth and a moral necessity. Even in those early days, I saw that breaking through the portals of power was not just a matter of fun. Governments depended on secrecy and patronage networks to deepen their advantages, but it began to appear possible that what street riots, opposition groups, human rights gurus and electoral reform had always struggled to achieve, we could actually begin to bring about with science. We could